



SPORTVIEW

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The Yankees' Choice

THE ANNOUNCEMENT THAT Steve Souchock will manage the Virginians will not start Richmond fans dancing in the streets. Why, some Richmond fans—those who had speculated whether the first Virginian manager under Yankee ownership would be Ralph Houk, Gerry Coleman or Enos Slaughter—most likely will react to the managerial appointment of Souchock with a two-word question: Who he?

The quickest and easiest answer to that question is that Souchock is the Yankees' choice to manage the first triple-A club the New York club has bought in more than 20 years. The Yankees are notorious for helping their own—when they believe their own can do the job. Obviously the Yankee brass, from General Manager George Weiss down, have confidence in Souchock.

Souchock, the past two seasons, managed the only club owned outright by the Yankees in a league bearing a higher classification than C. That club was Binghamton of the class A Eastern League. The New York club had working agreements with three clubs in higher classification than the Eastern League. Those working agreements included two with triple-A clubs—Denver of the American Association and Richmond of the International League. New Orleans, of the double-A Southern Association, also had a working agreement with the Yankees.

The Yankees selected the managers of the Richmond (Eddie Lopat) and the New Orleans (Charley Silvera) clubs. While Andy Cohen was the Denver club owner's personal choice to manage last year's club, a Yankee man, Houk, had managed the Denver club the first three seasons of the Yankees' four-year working agreement with Denver. But Souchock during the seasons of 1957-58, was the only manager wholly answerable to New York.

Moreover, since Silvera was let out as New Orleans' manager during the '57 season, Lopat had been recalled by the Yankees as pitching supervisor of the New York farm system, and Houk is Casey Stengel's first-base coach, Souchock was the lone experienced manager in the system.

That, in itself, would not have guaranteed Souchock the Virginians' job. Yankee officials had to have been satisfied with Souchock's managing at Binghamton where he won the Eastern League pennant in 1957 and the first-half championship, and league playoffs last season.

Baseball Farming Has Changed

TIME WAS, WHEN major league clubs owned nearly all the minor league franchises in league classifications from B to AAA, when the list of managers of Yankee-operated clubs was almost as imposing as the Yankee batting order.

At Norfolk, in the old Piedmont League, there were Bill Skiff . . . Johnny Neun . . . and Mayo Smith, among other managers. The likes of Bill Meyer, Skiff, Bruno Betzel and Phil Page managed Binghamton clubs for the parent Yankees. Kansas City managers, under Yankee ownership, included Babe Ganzel, Meyer, George Selkirk and Harry Craft. At Newark there were Al Mamaux . . . Bob Shawkey . . . Oscar Vitt . . . and Neun.

Five of those managers of Yankee-operated clubs became major league managers—Vitt, Neun, Meyer, Smith and Craft. In addition, Shawkey once served as an interim manager of the Yankee varsity club.

When the major league clubs changed their baseball farm systems by unloading their club holdings and going in for working agreements, the scouts and so-called trouble-shooters became more important to the major clubs than farm managers. Neun and Skiff are important links in the Yankee organization.

So long as the Yankees owned clubs in several minor league classifications the managers were brought along from league to league. Craft, for example, moved up from Joplin to Beaumont to Kansas City, where he now manages the American League club.

However, when Kansas City gained major league status and the Yankees formed a triple-A working agreement with Denver, the New York club dispatched Houk from the Yankee bull pen to manage its only triple-A affiliated club. When, the following year (1956) the Yankees entered into a partial working agreement with the Virginians, Lopat, without managerial experience, became the Richmond manager.

Mayhaps a Happy Augury

SOUCHOCK WILL COME here well grounded in the Yankee way. Long before he'd put in two seasons as a Yankee farm manager, he'd been a Yankee farm hand, and a Yankee. He played for Binghamton, Norfolk and Kansas City in the farm system, and with the New York club before being traded to Chicago before the 1949 season.

At the Vees' training camp he will not lack for familiar faces. Bobby Deakin and Deron Johnson, listed on the Virginians' winter roster, played for Souchock's 1957 Eastern League championship club, as did Clete Boyer, Ed Dick, Jim Bronstad and Frank Leja. The latter four Vee prospects were placed on the Yankees' winter roster for draft protection.

That Souchock has a winning way with young players was evidenced by the Virginian performances last season of Johnson, Boyer, Bronstad and Dick. It's a long jump from the class A Eastern League to the triple-A International League, but those four young 'uns proved good jumpers.

That pennant Souchock won at Binghamton in 1957 was the first championship for that city in 19 years. Let's see now. The last time a Richmond baseball club won a pennant was in 1940—19 years ago!